

COMMITTEE
MEMBERS'
PAPERS
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Lodge System of
Masonic
Education
Utah, 1961

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THE LODGE SYSTEM OF MASONIC EDUCATION

Prepared by
GRAND LODGE COMMITTEE
on

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THE LODGE SYSTEM OF MASONIC EDUCATION

FOREWORD

THE LODGE SYSTEM of Masonic Education adopted by the Grand Lodge is here, with set forth for the Worshipful Masters of the Lodges in the State of Utah.

It is simple, practicable, costs nothing; it is employed under the immediate authority and direction of the Lodge; it works at the point where education is most needed and best appreciated-namely with the candidate- and the results, if the method is used consistently, automatically guarantee themselves.

The Grand Lodge Committee on Masonic Education and Instruction recommends this system to every Worshipful Master. It has been thoroughly tested in the Grand Jurisdictions of New York and the District of Columbia and found completely satisfactory. It stands approved by the Grand Master and endorsed by many Craft leaders and brethren of wide experience in the field. A Lodge may use it in the full assurance that it will give perfect satisfaction.

THE PLAN IN BRIEF

The essentials of the Lodge System of Masonic Education are:

1. Its Name: The Lodge, rather than some independent organization carries it on.
2. Its Purpose: To see to it that every candidate is properly instructed in those fundamentals of the Craft which every newly made Mason ought to know.
3. Its Machinery: A committee of five members, or less, appointed by the Worshipful Master is all the machinery needed.
4. Its Method: The candidate meets with the committee once before receiving the First Degree and once after each Degree, including the Third-four times in all.

THE PURPOSE

Every candidate is a stranger to Freemasonry and Freemasonry is a stranger to him. It is not merely a Lodge that he joins but a Fraternity with about 6,830 members in thirty one Lodges in the State of Utah; with more than 4,125,000 members in approximately 16,000 Lodges in the United States of America; with other tens of thousands of members in other thousands of Lodges in other countries throughout the world; with a history stretching back over many centuries; an intricate system of laws, a large number of purposes, ideals and obligations; many rights, privileges and duties; the Ancient Landmarks to be preserved; the whole carrying on a program of activities of great variety.

It is too much to expect that, without guidance, any man will be able to make himself at home in such a society, or un-aided, take his proper place in the Lodge's work with credit to himself and honor to the Brotherhood. He has the right to expect that the Lodge will give him much of the information he needs. It is because so many brethren

never receive this information, and are permitted to come-and perhaps to go-undirected and uninstructed, that they cease to attend Lodge.

For years responsible Craft leaders have realized that failure properly to prepare the candidate for his new duties and privileges is a failure on the part of the Craft to discharge its just obligations, and a weakness in the fundamental system of initiation which incurs the danger of weakening the whole structure by attempting to build enduring walls with rough ashlar and untempered mortar.

It is necessary that new brethren become imbued with the spirit of Freemasonry and to believe in, as well as to understand, its purposes and ideals. When Masons cause dissension in a Lodge it is seldom from a desire to make mischief but because they do not understand the rules and laws.

The system here recommended takes in every candidate, automatically and without exception; it is an enterprise of the Lodge, under the direct control of the Master; a regular, recognized and continuing part of the Lodge's own proper work. Not only the candidate profits; the Lodge is strengthened by having new members who from the beginning, are able to take part in its activities; who are likely to become regular attendants; who can quickly grasp the aim and purpose of the Lodge's endeavors. They come in ready and prepared for work.

METHOD AND MACHINERY

The method and machinery of the
Lodge System of Masonic Education is:

1. The Worshipful Master appoints a Committee of five or less.
2. After a petition has been favorably balloted upon, the petitioner is notified by the Secretary to meet with the committee at a specified time and place.
3. On this first evening the committee will give him such instructions as he needs to enable him to receive the First Degree in a proper spirit and furnish him such information about the principles and teachings of Masonry as will give him a clear understanding of what kind of society he is about to enter.
4. The candidate, again instructed by the Master through the Secretary, will meet with this committee three more times, once after each of the Degrees. When ready to consummate his membership he can do so intelligently with clear knowledge of “what it is all about.”

THE COMMITTEE

The committee should be composed of Master Masons of experience, knowledge and tact, who feel a genuine interest in their work and who can be trusted not to neglect it. It is wise to have at least one Past Master in its membership. The committee should have a chairman but needs no other officers; if desired, the chairman can report to the Lodge upon each candidate after the latter has attended his fourth (and last) meeting.

The candidate meets the committee at the specified time and place and hears a few words of greeting from the chairman in explanation of the purpose and spirit of the meeting. After that he listens while each member in turn reads (or recites) one of the five papers herewith printed under the heading, "First Meeting." When the candidate has heard the five subjects presented he can then be encouraged to ask questions and take part in an informal discussion, the committee explaining any questions to which the presentation of subjects has given rise. If ten minutes be allowed for preliminaries, fifty for the subjects and thirty for questions and discussion, the entire time will be only one- and one-half hours.

The candidate has nothing to do but listen; no books to read, no papers to write, nothing to memorize; it adds nothing to his burden of mastering his Catechism.

But the gain to him is inestimable; when he is ready to sign the by-laws, he will have heard twenty fundamental subjects presented, a larger amount of carefully digested, useful, connected information than many Masons have been able to pick up, when left to their own resources, in twenty years.

Nor is the system a great burden on the committee. Once a member has learned his subjects, he has nothing more to do save attend the meetings; a privilege and a pleasure, since it will give him the satisfaction of feeling that he has an important share in preparing a brother for his life in Masonry.

It is important that every committee member confine himself to the subjects as written. First, it guarantees that the member will take the same amount of time at every meeting and not run on and on, as often happens. Second, it assures that all candidates hear the same papers. Third, it enables the chairman to call in a substitute at a moment's notice if a member cannot attend. Fourth, since the papers have been approved by the Grand Lodge Committee on Masonic Education and Instruction, each candidate hears only that which has been authorized and has back of it the weight and responsibility of the Grand Lodge.

Too much importance cannot be laid upon this need to have the candidate know that what he hears is not the random opinion of some chance individual but a statement sanctioned by the Craft and, therefore, to be believed, accepted in all seriousness and acted upon. Further to make sure of this, it may be wise in beginning the system, to have one each of the four meetings held in open Lodge, opened on the appropriate Degree, except in the first meeting, which may be held prior to opening or after closing Lodge. By such a series of exhibition meetings the whole Lodge can see what the system is and how it works.

(Note to the Worshipful Master: It is important that educated, intelligent men be appointed to this committee - men who read intelligibly and with expression. It is also very important that no one having another appointment for a later hour in the evening attend these committee meetings. Frequent consultation of watches tends to disrupt the line of thought.)

PROGRAMS FOR FOUR MEETINGS

The First Meeting

(Preceding the First Degree)

The purpose of the first meeting is to introduce the candidate to Freemasonry as a whole and prepare him. In mind and spirit to receive initiation. He is entering a strange country; his teachers will give him the necessary guidance and point out the landmarks by which he will steer his course. And it will be impressed upon him that becoming a Mason is not a light or frivolous undertaking, but fraught with important consequences, and that Initiation, Passing and Raising are not perfunctory ceremonies to be entered into with a light heart, but the first and all-important steps into the world of Freemasonry. He will learn that Freemasonry is a life to be lived, not a set of hollow forms to be hypocritically observed; that he must first become prepared in his heart. Also, he will learn that in the committee he has guides and friends to whom he can come for counsel.

For these purposes five papers on as many subjects are printed herewith for the use of the committee. These are:

1. A Short History of Freemasonry.
2. The Duties and Privileges of Lodge Membership.
3. The Machinery and Organization of a Lodge.
4. The Landmarks.
5. Freemasonry's Attitude to Politics and Religion.

The Second Meeting

(Preceding the Second Degree)

The candidate is now an Entered Apprentice. His initiation has been an experience very different from what his anticipation had pictured it; he feels somewhat mystified by a ceremony so unlike anything else he has ever seen; the language has been strange, the symbols unusual. He is puzzled as to what it all means; moreover, he is now an Entered Apprentice and is wondering what he is next to do, and what his duties and privileges are. The purpose of the meeting is to explain all these to him, giving him an interpretation of the Degree, describing what an Apprentice can and cannot do, and preparing him for the next step.

To this end the following five subjects are herewith presented:

1. Duties, Privileges and Limitations of an Entered Apprentice.
2. What Masonry Owes to Architecture.
3. Symbols of the First Degree.
4. Place of the Obligations in Masonic Law.
5. The Mason as a Citizen.

The Third Meeting

(Preceding the Third Degree)

For a reason difficult to understand, the Degree of Fellowcraft seldom commands either the attention or the interest of the other two. In reality it is a great Degree, crowded with thoughts of importance, and its explanation offers a golden opportunity to present all the aspects of Freemasonry's appeal to the intellect, since education, symbolized by the Liberal Arts and Sciences, is its heart.

The candidate is now midway in his journey. Having participated in two degrees and met twice with the committee, he begins to feel more at home. If, in the beginning, he came with the secret expectation that initiation would be a kind of hazing, full of pranks and horseplay, or possibly a painful ordeal, he has learned better. In his present state of mind, he should be ready to learn something of the more difficult themes in history and symbolism.

The First Degree made its principal appeal to the conscience; the candidate was an Apprentice, a beginner, a learner; therefore, it was impressed upon him that he must live in obedience to his superiors and follow carefully his guides and teachers. The Third Degree, yet to come, will make a spiritual appeal, treating of evil, the human heart, death, immortality. It will address itself to the soul. By contrast to each of these, the Second Degree addresses the intellectual faculties; it is Masonry appealing to the mind.

The Liberal Arts and Sciences assisted by the five senses climb the symbolical steps to a Middle Chamber wherein wisdom is found in the midst of culture and refinement. A picture of the awakening and cultivation of the mind under the influences of Masonry stands impressively and dominantly in the center of this, one of the finest and most beautiful degrees in Masonry. The committee, therefore, in its third meeting will lay emphasis on the philosophy of Masonry, its great teachings, its messages of education; the ways that lead to the enlightened mind and the rewards of a cultivation of the faculties and the senses. For this purpose, these five subjects are herewith presented:

1. Interpretation of the Ritual of the Second Degree.
2. Symbols and Allegories of the Second Degree.
3. Duties and Privileges of a Fellowcraft.
4. The Teachings of Masonry.
5. Masonic Education.

The Fourth Meeting

(Following the Third Degree)

It is a standing misfortune that so often a candidate is permitted to drop from sight immediately after he has received the Third Degree, and is left to his own devices, compelled to find his way as best he can. It is the most critical period in his Masonic career. If the Lodge can keep a hold on him, give him guidance and encouragement until he has had time to form habits of interest and activity for himself, he will develop into a working Mason; otherwise he is likely to cease attending after two or three meetings and lapse into chronic indifference.

His initiation is only a beginning. He needs to know and to understand his duties as a Master Mason; what are his rights, privileges and his financial obligations; he should be taught how to visit other Lodges; he needs information about Grand Lodge itself, about the traditions and work of the Craft as a whole; at no other time in his Masonic career will he be so eager or so quick to learn as in the impressionable period immediately following the Third Degree.

That Degree is at once the climax of initiation in the Symbolic Lodge and the greatest, the most profound, the most influential degree in Masonry. The time for him to learn its meaning is while it remains fresh in his memory and warm in his feelings.

In its fourth meeting the committee has opportunity to put him into possession of that meaning, as well as to give him the more general information described in the paragraphs above. It is a golden opportunity to help one who has just become a member in name to become a Mason in fact, in the sense that throughout his Masonic career he will continue serving and working for the Craft. To this end the following five subjects are herewith presented:

1. Interpretation of the Ritual of the Third Degree.
2. Symbols, Emblems and Allegories of the Third Degree.
3. The Legend of Hiram Abif.
4. The Duties, Privileges and Rights of a Master Mason.
5. The Grand Lodge Library and the Literature of Masonry.

CONCLUSION

It is hoped that the above outline, discussion and suggestions may not have obscured the great simplicity of the Lodge System of Masonic Education. To make assurance doubly sure:

1. The System may be put into effect by a Master or it may be adopted by a vote of the Lodge members after discussion in open Lodge.
2. The Worshipful Master appoints a committee of five.
3. A Chairman is named, either by appointment by the Master or by election by the committee.
4. Each candidate (or class of candidates) is required to meet with this committee four times, once before the First Degree and once after each of the First, Second, and Third Degrees.
5. At every meeting each committee member reads from manuscript or recites from memory one of the ten-minute papers herewith provided.
6. The papers are followed by a period of question and discussion.

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A Short History of Freemasonry

Meeting No. 1

Subject No. 1

Tonight, I shall tell you a little about the story of Freemasonry the better to enable you to understand the three steps of initiation which lie before you.

Men of all ages and of all lands have had secret societies, have used ceremonies of initiation, employed symbols, emblems and means of recognition. When Freemasonry came into existence, nobody knows how many centuries ago, it inherited from such societies many of its rites and a number of its symbols. During your initiation ceremonies you will encounter them.

The oldest existing written record of our Craft is a manuscript written about 1390. This document itself shows that Freemasonry was, even then, very old.

At the time this document was written all Masons were Operative - that is, they were workers engaged in the construction of buildings. A Master Mason or Freemason was a man who had served his apprenticeship and was no longer a bondman but freed as a consequence of his having served his time and become a Master of his Craft. Such men designed, supervised and erected cathedrals and other marvelous Gothic edifices of Europe. Their work was difficult, called for a high degree of skill and genius, required a complete knowledge of mechanics and geometry. They were the great artisans of the Middle Ages.

Training men for such work required a long period of severe discipline. Boys, sound in body and mind and of good reputation, were selected at the age of ten or twelve and apprenticed to some Master Mason for about seven years. This Master Mason became the boy's tutor, monitor, guide, and taught him all the theories and practices of

the Craft. At the end of his apprenticeship the youth was required to submit to exacting tests of his proficiency before being accepted by the Craft as a Master Mason.

When Masons congregated in readiness to commence the construction of an edifice, they organized a Lodge which met in a temporary building. Such a Lodge was governed by a Worshipful Master assisted by Wardens, divided its membership into grades, admitted members by initiation and was, in short, what a Masonic Lodge is to-day.

The beginner learning the builder's trade was called an Apprentice. After he had served sufficient time to give evidence of his fitness, he was entered on the Lodge's books, after which he was called an Entered Apprentice. Upon completion of his apprenticeship he was called into open Lodge, his conduct reported, and he was set to prove his skill by producing his "Master's Piece." If he passed his test satisfactorily he became a full member of the Craft, with all of its duties, rights and privileges and was called a "Fellow of the Craft"; in the sense that he had mastered the duties, rules, practices secrets and tools of his trade he was called; Master Mason.

Such was the Fraternity in its Operative period; and as such it flourished for generations.

Then came a change: The Reformation came, and the Gothic style of architecture began to die out; social conditions changed; laws were changed. These and many other factors brought about a decline in the Craft. During the 16th and 17th Centuries Freemasons became few in number. Their numbers then increased through admission into their ranks of gentlemen - men not interested in building construction - who were attracted by their morality, and perhaps out of curiosity, or for social reasons. And because they were thus accepted, they were called "Accepted Masons." Their number increased until, in the early part of the 18th century, they outnumbered the Operatives in number and influence.

As a result of this, four or more "Old Lodges" of London and Westminster met and organized the first Grand Lodge. Within a few

years the Craft had transformed itself from an Operative Body into a Speculative Fraternity (by Speculative is meant Masonry in a moral or symbolical sense); reorganized the old two degrees into the three degrees of Entered Apprentice, Fellowcraft and Master Mason, collected the old manuscripts, produced the First Book of Constitutions and chartered Lodges in many countries including our own.

In 1751 a second Grand Lodge was organized in England and, later on, the two Grand Lodges consolidated and organized the United Grand Lodge.

Early American Lodges, organized about 1730, were placed under the charge of Provincial Grand Lodges which were ruled by Provincial Grand Masters appointed by Grand Lodges in England, Scotland or Ireland.

As a result of the American Revolution, American Grand Lodges became sovereign and independent. As the years passed a Grand Lodge has been organized in each State and is sovereign within its territorial limits. Today we have in the United States 49 Grand Lodges (one being in the District of Columbia) about 16,000 Lodges and more than 4,000,000 members.

Operative Masons erected buildings. We as Masons, try to build character, manhood. Their tools we have transformed into emblems of moral and spiritual laws and forces; their rituals we employ in the initiation of our candidates and as you enter into it you will discover it a power in your life to ennoble and inspire.

The Duties and Privileges of Lodge Membership

Meeting No. 1

Subject No. 2

In petitioning for the Three Degrees of Masonry your desire was to become a member of a Lodge. When the members of this Lodge elected you to receive the Degrees it was with the understanding that you would ultimately become a member of this or some other Lodge. Therefore, I have been delegated to speak to you on the duties and privileges of Lodge membership. Of course, there is much that cannot at this time be explained to you but there is much that you should understand at this stage of your Journey.

You will become a member of a Lodge by receiving the Three Degrees, by proving your proficiency in each of them and by signing the By-Laws. The relationship is contractual-that is, you bind yourself to perform certain duties and the Lodge binds itself to protect you in certain rights and privileges.

One of the first of your duties will be loyalty to the Fraternity, faithfulness to your superior officers and obedience to the laws and the Landmarks.

It will be your duty to hold membership in some Lodge, and if any Mason remains unaffiliated with a Lodge for six months, he is denied desirable rights and privileges.

It will be your duty to pay your dues promptly; and, as your conscience shall guide and your means permit, to lend a helping hand to a Brother Mason in sickness or distress.

If you are present at a regular meeting of the Lodge when a ballot is held on a petition for initiation or affiliation, you must vote-it is required by Masonic law.

It will be your duty to attend meetings of your Lodge, to join in its deliberations, to have a voice in its decisions and to assist in

discharging its responsibilities. You will not be expected to attend, however, if it works a hardship on yourself or your family.

If the Worshipful Master, acting in accordance with Constitutional provisions, issues a summons to you to attend a meeting of the Lodge for some special purpose or to discharge some Masonic duty, it will be your duty to obey the summons if within the scope of your reasonable ability to do so.

Other duties will be made dear to you as you progress. Lodge membership is not a mere gesture of honor nor an idle privilege, nor does it mean that a member has the privilege of evading his responsibilities by shifting his duties to more willing shoulders- the “let George do it” kind. The Mystic Tie by which he is bound to his fellows has in it a strand of steel held fast by stringent laws, to ignore which is to incur discipline.

I shall now explain some of the rights and privileges which are made equally secure by the Fraternity.

If you move away from the jurisdiction of your Lodge you will have the right to transfer your membership provided you are in good standing in the first Lodge and your petition is favorably acted upon in the second Lodge.

A member of a Lodge is eligible to any office except that of Master. He is eligible to the office of Master if he has been previously installed as a Warden or Master.

You will have the right to visit any Lodge anywhere, provided the Worshipful Master is willing to admit you after you have been vouched for or examined.

As a Master Mason in good standing you will have the right to join in public processions, a privilege carefully guarded by our laws, since, to join in such is public identification with the Fraternity.

In case of death you will be entitled to Masonic burial unless your conduct in life reflected discreditably upon the Fraternity.

Besides, it means that your family may to a certain extent be brought within the care of a Lodge at a time, perhaps, when friendly counsel is needed.

If you, unfortunately, expose yourself to formal discipline, you will have the right of hearing, of counsel, of appearing in your own defense, of submitting evidence, of trial by Masons and, if found guilty, of making appeal to Grand Lodge.

The Lodge and the Grand Lodge give many services and extend many opportunities for entertainment and educational advantages. As a Master Mason you will have the privilege of enjoying these equally with all others.

When among strangers you will have certain modes of recognition by which to prove yourself to another Master Mason.

You are not to understand that these duties, rights and privileges of Masonic membership are exhaustive. The above are but a few of them: but we trust that, with the light which this has given, you will go forward with a livelier understanding of what Masonry will mean to you and of what, we trust, you may mean to Masonry.

The Machinery and Organization of a Lodge

Meeting No. 1

Subject No. 3

You have been elected to receive the Degrees of Masonry. Before you become a member, you will appear three times in the Lodge to receive the Degrees. Since you will thus come into contact with the Lodge and later become a member, it will be of assistance to you to learn how a Lodge is organized and what its machinery is. Much about a Lodge is secret, to be learned only through initiation; what is now told you is written in the Code of Laws of our Grand Lodge.

A Lodge is an organization of seven or more Master Masons empowered by a Grand Lodge to confer the Three Degrees of Masonry and to do such work and to carry on such activities as appertain thereto.

Authority is conferred by a Charter issued by a Grand Lodge. you will later be shown the Charter of our own Lodge. It was issued to us by the Grand Lodge of Free and Accepted Masons of Utah.

A Lodge can retain its Charter only as it obeys the laws of the Grand Lodge and works according to the traditions, ancient usages and customs of the Masonic Fraternity.

Each Lodge can make Masons only of such elected petitioners as live within its jurisdiction. If there be only one Lodge in a city, all persons residing nearer to it by an air line than to any other Lodge must petition it for the Degrees; If there be more than one Lodge, they have concurrent jurisdiction-that is, a petitioner may make his choice among them.

A Lodge is governed by the Grand Lodge according to laws laid down in the Grand Lodge Code of Laws. Those laws define the province within which a Lodge governs itself. Certain of the laws and

rules of its self-government are embodied in its By-Laws, a copy of which you will be required to sign when you become a member.

Each Lodge in this Jurisdiction has at least ten officers, five of whom are chosen by ballot. These are the Worshipful Master, Senior Warden, Junior Warden, Secretary and Treasurer. They are elected at the first regular meeting in December.

The primary executive power of the Lodge is vested in the office of Worshipful Master.

The Senior Warden is the second ranking officer. If the Worshipful Master be absent, the Senior Warden presides in his place. If, through absence or inability the office of Worshipful Master becomes vacant, the Senior Warden succeeds to all his prerogatives and duties for all purposes except such as pertain to the installation of officers. The Senior Warden has other duties which you will learn later.

Next in rank is the Junior Warden who governs the Lodge in the absence or inability of the Worshipful Master and Senior Warden.

Neither a Master nor Warden may resign his office.

The Secretary of the Lodge keeps its minutes, receives all money due the Lodge and pays it to the Treasurer, prepares reports to Grand Lodge, conducts its correspondence, files petitions, etc.

The Treasurer receives Lodge money from the Secretary, keeps a true account of it and pays it out by order of the Lodge upon warrants certified by the Master and Secretary.

The Tiler guards the outer door to see that no one enters the Lodge except those entitled to do so.

In addition to its officers a Lodge has various standing and special committees.

The meetings of the Lodge are of two kinds, regular and special. Regular meetings are held on dates set by the By-Laws. Special meetings are called by the Worshipful Master.

There are three Degrees in Masonry. These are conferred only at meetings of the Lodge, either regular or special. An Entered Apprentice may sit in a Lodge only when it is working on that Degree; a Fellowcraft, only when in the Fellowcraft or Entered Apprentice Degrees. A member of the Lodge has the right to sit in it and to vote in any meeting. Visitors may sit in it only by consent of the Worshipful Master.

A man cannot petition for the Degrees unless he has resided in the State for twelve months and in the jurisdiction of the Lodge at least six months. There are certain exceptions to this rule which you will learn later.

The petitioner must sign his full name to his petition and satisfactorily answer a list of questions. His petition must also be signed by two members of the Lodge he petitions.

The Lodge receives his petition at a regular meeting, after which it is referred to an investigating committee of three members who return a report in writing. The Lodge must ballot on the petition at a regular meeting. To be elected the petitioner must receive an unanimously favorable ballot. The one ballot elects for all three degrees.

Before receiving the Degrees, a petitioner must pay an initiation fee fixed in the Lodge By-Laws. When he becomes a member, he must pay annual dues, also fixed in the By-Laws. These fees and dues comprise the principal sources of income of a Lodge. The Lodge may also receive income from endowments and other similar sources. For each candidate initiated the Lodge must pay a fee to Grand Lodge; and for each member it must also pay annual dues.

In brief outline and to the extent to which you can now understand it, such is the machinery and form of organization of a Masonic Lodge. It conveys only a hint of the rich life and manifold activities of a Lodge as a member knows them. In due course you will enjoy privileges of membership in this Lodge and find it exceeds all your expectations.

The Landmarks

Meeting No. 1

Subject No. 4.

Freemasonry has honored the term "Landmarks" as a name for one of the most important of its basic laws, namely, that there are in the Craft certain principles, practices, traditions, usages or laws which cannot be changed by any Mason, Lodge or Grand Lodge. It is this we mean when we speak of "The Ancient Landmarks", a phrase you will hear often during your Masonic career. Let us see if we can explain that phrase, at least in its larger meaning.

Freemasonry has an identity, a character of its own. Some things in it can be abolished, changed or modified, without destroying that identity-that is, after the change is made Freemasonry continues to be what it was before. But there are other changes which, if they were made, would destroy Freemasonry itself-that is, it would cease to have its own identity and would become something else.

Landmarks signify that which in Masonry is essential to its identity.

Let me call your attention briefly to a few examples which will make the meaning clear- remembering that these are by no means the complete list.

Many of the things in Masonry are kept secret from the outside world. This secrecy is not a theatrical pose but is so essential to the very nature of the Craft that we could not conceive of Masonry without it. Gone would be the ritual, initiation, the obligations, the modes of recognition and all that home-like privacy that makes Lodge-life delightful. Secrecy, therefore, has the power of a Landmark.

Ever since it began, Masonry has admitted adult men only to membership. A boy under age could not be held accountable to his obligations; and if women were admitted it would call for such a recasting of our system from top to bottom that little of it would remain standing.

Again, each petitioner is required to possess certain qualifications, must be sound of limb, well recommended, of good character, free born, of mature age. If these qualifications were removed, men of every sort would be admitted, men not physically, mentally or morally capable of living the Masonic life; the result would be no Masonry to live.

But it is not sufficient for a petitioner to be well qualified in order to gain admittance; he must also pass through the rites of initiation. This also has been an integral part of our Fraternity from the very beginning and it is so vital to it that the whole system presupposes it throughout.

The Ritual, with its assemblage of symbols, emblems and allegories, is yet another character belonging to the nature of Masonry.

Another equally essential factor is the secret, unanimous ballot. Since it is the principal purpose of the Craft to bring men together into brotherly relation, it is necessary that such candidates as are admitted shall not disturb harmony among its members.

My last example: Belief in God, with the Altar at the center of the Lodge and having the Holy Bible open upon it; hope of immortality, belief in prayer--here is the religious basis of Freemasonry--and I use the word basis literally. If this spiritual life were destroyed, our Fraternity would degenerate into a mere social club---something diametrically opposed to what it is.

I have given you this explanation of the principle of the Landmarks through a series of examples for one purpose. When I state that purpose I shall have concluded.

You are not yet a Mason. If you have the good fortune to become a member of a Lodge and if, thereafter, you progress in Masonic knowledge and experience as we trust you may, then you will win an understanding of this subject in a more technical manner and you will have the advantage of seeing it from the inside instead of from the outside. But at your present stage the subject is of the utmost

importance to you, and for this reason: it makes plain to you that Freemasonry is clearly conscious of what belongs to its own proper nature; against every possible influence it guards and cherishes that nature continually; the petitioner who comes into its membership must accept it as he finds it or not at all. There is no way to change Masonry to suit the tastes, foibles, prejudices or opinions of the candidate; it is the candidate who must change himself to conform to Masonry. To become a Mason, therefore, you must stand ready with all sincerity to give whole-hearted assent to its teachings and principles, obedience to its laws and regulations and observance to its Ancient Landmarks.

Freemasonry's Attitude to Politics and Religion

Meeting No. 1

Subject No. 5

You have already learned that in Masonry there are certain basic rules and principles called Landmarks. These Landmarks are an expression of that which belongs to Masonry's identity; if they were cancelled out Masonry would cease to be Masonry.

One of the most important of all those Landmarks is that which forbids us to participate, AS MASONS, in any form of religious or political sectarianism. We must not discuss such matters in any of our assemblies; and we cannot take any kind of public action with regard to them in the name of the Craft. A candidate must acknowledge a belief in God, a hope for immortality and reverence the Holy Bible as a rule and guide for his life. The doctrinal interpretation he may place on this belief must, however, be left entirely to him. So also, must he pledge himself to good citizenship but his choice of a political party through which he works for the realization of his ideal of citizenship, must be left entirely to him.

It is noteworthy that nothing is more likely to divide and alienate men than religious and political sectarianism. For this reason, sectarianism is prohibited because the needs and the welfare of Brotherhood demand it.

During its whole history the Fraternity has been subject to attacks from without. In our own country a hundred years ago a coalition of certain churches with a national political party undertook to stamp Masonry out of existence. Two or three of the great churches of the world still maintain that same attitude toward it. And only a few years ago several great governments have sought to outlaw it by governmental action. In all probability our Craft always will have such enemies to deal with, as does every other organization.

Our attitude toward such attacks is to ignore them. We do not fight back. We take the position that if some man, or group of men, disagrees with the teachings of Freemasonry, that is his own private affair and does not concern us. We do nothing to invite or warrant such attacks, therefore, they are no affair of ours.

Tolerance has always been one of the fundamental principles of our Fraternity. By it we DO NOT mean that one belief is as true as another, or as valuable as another; we do not advocate a general indifference to all beliefs. Tolerance encourages each man to think for himself. Tolerance means what the word implies: To put up with the religious beliefs of other men and respect them for the same reason that we like to have our own beliefs respected and without discussion or argument.

Freemasonry is dedicated to and devoted to Brotherhood. But this Brotherhood rests on a basis of religion. Every Mason believes in God. The Bible must be open on every Lodge Altar. Before engaging in any important undertaking, a Mason seeks aid and guidance through prayer. This is religion but is not a religion. It is faith but is not a faith confined to any one creed. It is worship but is not a worship chained to any one altar. In the words of the "First Book of Constitutions" it is the religion "in which all good men agree." It is the ground which underlies all religions, all churches, all creeds, and sects.

Politics means the discussion and determination of matters of public policy. Each question of national policy is, therefore, of politics, consequently, matters of politics are of the utmost importance and concern to any nation. Every citizen, if he be a good citizen, will bring to bear on such questions his best judgment and will do whatever his duty demands toward putting into effect such policies as are determined on.

This is good citizenship and Masonry demands of every member that he be a good citizen. Just as we saw that the religion of Masonry is that common ground which underlies all religious parties, so is this good citizenship the common ground under all political parties. A Mason may adhere to this political party or to that, may hold one

opinion or another about the tariff; but whatever be his party or his opinion, he must be a good citizen- law--abiding, faithful to the nation, loyal to the civil powers.

To sum up:

As a Mason you will never introduce into the Craft any controversial sectarian question; you will pay no heed to those from without who may attack the Fraternity; you will adhere to that religion in which all good men agree, and in your life as a member of the State you will be loyal to the demands of good citizenship.

Duties, Privileges, and Limitations of An Entered Apprentice

Meeting No. 2

Subject No. 1

The limitations under which an Entered Apprentice works are easily described. He cannot belong to a Lodge, vote or hold office; it is only after he has received the Master Mason Degree and signed the By-Laws of his Lodge that he can consummate his membership. And since Masonic Law provides that only members can vote or hold office, he is not yet entitled to these rights. He is not entitled to Masonic burial nor can he walk in public Masonic processions. An Apprentice is not yet a full-fledged Mason; he is still on probation and the Craft has not yet received him as a member. An Apprentice cannot visit or sit in a Lodge except when open on the First Degree. Since all the business of a Lodge is conducted in the Third Degree, this means that he has no voice in its discussion, no vote in its decisions.

Nevertheless, he possesses certain important rights and privileges. He has the right to be coached in this work and to be instructed in matters pertaining to his Degree. If charged with violating his obligation, he is entitled to trial. He has the right to apply for advancement to a higher Degree; this means that he cannot be stopped at his first step through negligence or indifference, or through opposition owing to prejudice. If any member of the Lodge believes that he is unworthy to pass to the Degree of Fellowcraft the question may be decided at a meeting by a majority of the members present at a meeting at which the matter is presented by a committee appointed to investigate the objection. Also, the Apprentice possesses modes of recognition by means of which he can make himself known to other Apprentices and he has the privilege of using them.

Of his duties the chief is to be faithful to his obligation, the clauses of which clearly describe what he is to do and not to do; the obligation is as binding on him as the obligation of the Third Degree is

binding on Master Masons. If, by any chance, he be charged with un-Masonic conduct, the charge will be examined and tried by the Lodge. As an Apprentice you would study it so carefully that both its words and its meaning will remain with you as long as you live.

By the same token it is the duty of the Apprentice to learn the Catechism of the Degree with equal thoroughness because he must prove himself proficient in it in order to make advancement. The lessons thus memorized will remain with him forever. The First Degree is not to be considered a temporary stopping place, to be forgotten when the next Degree is reached; the Degree, rather, is an end in and of itself, perfect and complete within its own field, and its great purpose is that the candidate shall BE an Apprenticed Mason in the sense that its teachings shall become a permanent part of his being.

The Apprentice is on probation, - he is passing through a period of instruction and testing; therefore, it is his duty to be obedient, trusting himself to his guides and quick

to respond to the instructions of the officers of the Lodge in a spirit of humbleness. It is not for him to question what he finds, to discuss the Lodge, or to set himself up as a critic. His presence in the Craft is at yet on sufferance. Nor can he as yet possibly know enough about it to criticize. The clue to his whole position is furnished in the word "Apprentice" itself, which means learner; since he is by status a learner, his chief object is to learn and to learn he must respect his teachers and follow their instructions.

Freemasonry stands in a different case altogether from a golf club or a card club; it preserves a secrecy about all its work; it meets behind tiled doors; it throws over its principles and teachings a garment of symbolism and ritual; its Art is a mystery; a great wall and high separates it from the profane world; it is a \world in itself · standing silently within the great world. Nor is its work so easy to understand as a hand at game of golf, but is often very difficult and is carried forward in the high and responsible regions of the religious, moral, and intellectual life.

For such reasons there is almost nothing in common between it and all those social or entertaining societies which serve as playgrounds for men.

A petitioner who knocks at its portals possesses very slight knowledge of what lies within, brings with him little or no previous preparation; and once he steps inside, he discovers that Masonry lies stretching away before him like a great continent across which he must make long and often difficult journeys in order to reach his goal. The night on which he receives his Master Mason Degree marks, not the end of his journey but only its beginning. The task of learning Masonry, of becoming adept in its work, of fashioning his life according to its requirements, is still before him. In a narrow and technical sense he ceased to be an Apprentice the moment he had taken the Fellowcraft obligation, but in the larger and truer sense he remains an Apprentice until he has mastered Masonic work and is able to take his place in the quarries.

Once he is elected it is not difficult for a candidate to become a member in name and appearance only; but we are sure that your own ambition extends far beyond that perfunctory stage. We believe that you desire to become a Mason in reality and that no idle desire for the honor of bearing the name has been your motive for seeking our fellowship. If this be true, we both urge and advise you not to be content with the letter and outward form only in this, your beginning period, but that rather you will apply yourself with toil, with zeal and with self-sacrifice to the sincere and thorough mastering of our Royal Art.

What Freemasonry Owes to Architecture

Meeting No. 2

Subject No. 2

In its earliest period, as you know, our Craft was composed wholly of men engaged in Architecture, or in the practice of some branch of the building arts as a means of livelihood. They had a kind of general Fraternity, and when they gathered at some point to work on a building, a cathedral perhaps, they organized Lodges. We know the Craft of this early period by the name of "Operative Masonry." As time passed Operative Masonry underwent a series of gradual changes until, in the first quarter of the eighteenth century, it became transformed into our present Fraternity of Speculative Freemasonry. But the advent of Speculative Freemasonry did not destroy the old foundation of Operative Masonry; on the contrary, very much of it was preserved and we today are the heirs of many things that have come down to us from our Operative forefathers. I shall now indicate a few of those inheritances.

A large number of our symbols originated in the art of Architecture. You will immediately recall a few of these, for you have already encountered them in the First Degree. But, there are many others. The Working Tools: The Square and Compasses are two of the Great Lights; the cornerstone; the Northeast Corner; the two Ashlars; the Oblong Square; Parallel Lines; each of these arose in the practice of the Operative Masons and there are scores besides. When, therefore, you come to interpret these symbols for yourself, it will be necessary for you to make your start from that fact. Your first questions will be:

What did this tool or this idea mean to the Operative Mason while he was at work on a building? Your next step will be to see that it has the same kind of meaning in all other kinds of work, of building, of constructive endeavor, even in the effort to build character and a

spiritual life. When you have come to all this larger and more general meaning in such a way that you can make use of it in your own daily affairs, you will have grasped the symbolic meaning, for this is just what is meant by symbolism.

Consider, as a special example of this, the Working Tools. It is plain to everybody that in the beginning these were nothing but the tools the Operative Mason used in his work; he had to cut, measure, smooth or carve a stone to make it fit into its proper place in the building structure, and the plumb, square, level, gavel, gauge and trowel were necessarily the tools he had to use. But a stone is not the only thing that has to be measured or shaped, or carved to fit into a place or function. It is also true of a man's mind, of his character. Each man has his own proper place in society; as a worker, as a citizen, as the head of a family, as a neighbor, as a Lodge member. Will he fit into his proper place or will he be a misfit? The question will be decided by how thoroughly and intelligently he uses on himself the methods and influences that are necessary to give shape to his life. Those methods and influences are symbolized by the Working Tools.

By this time, you have learned that Freemasonry is a Fraternity devoted to Brotherhood; to maintain Brotherhood among its own members and to work for it in the world at large is its reason for existence. The erection of a Gothic cathedral called for many workmen; the building was erected according to a plan and this required that each man govern his work accordingly. A group of men thus organized together, all working harmoniously to the same end, constitute a Brotherhood; this Masonic Brotherhood, therefore, instead of being the result of a mere vague aspiration, was a product of the practice of the art of architecture as that art then was.

We do not achieve Brotherhood by a random sentimentality, merely by shaking hands and patting each other on the back, but by our all working together at the same task. Most of the great things in this world must be done, if ever they are to be done at all, by co-operative enterprise, and unless a man is able to co-operate, he cannot have a share in doing them.

We hope that you may learn to detect all our architectural symbols and emblems; that you may study them, reflect and ponder them and seek to learn what they mean for you in your own experience.

Symbols of the First Degree

Meeting No. 2

Subject No. 3

The symbols, emblems and allegorical ceremonies of the First Degree have each a meaning and these meanings comprise the teaching of the Degree. We believe that it will be profitable to you to have a few hints and suggestions, as they will show that every detail of the Ritual is filled with a definite significance which each Mason can learn if he applies himself.

The Hoodwink represents the darkness in which an uninitiated man stands as regards the Masonic life; for this reason, it is removed at the moment of enlightenment. Its removal suggests that we do not make the great things of existence but find them; it is our blindness that conceals them from us.

The Cable Tow is a symbol of all those earthly restraints by which a man is controlled by others or by forces outside himself. If a man does not keep the law of his own free will, he must be compelled to keep it by compulsion. The removal of the Cable Tow means that when a man becomes master of himself, he will keep the law instinctively, out of his own character.

The Lodge is a symbol of the world. The symbol means that in its scope and extent Freemasonry is as broad as human nature and as wide as mankind, and that as a spirit and ideal it permeates the whole life of every true Mason, outside the Lodge as well as inside.

The Ceremony of Entrance by which is meant all that happens at the Inner Door, signifies birth or initiation and symbolizes the fact that a candidate is entering the world of Masonry, there to live a new kind of life.

The Sharp Instrument means that which is the one real penalty for violations of the Obligations, the destructive consequences to a man's nature of being faithless to his vows, untrue to his word.

The Rite of Circumambulation is Masonry 's name for the ceremony of walking around the Lodge-room, an allegorical act rich with many meanings. One of the principal of these is that the Masonic life is a progressive journey, from station to station of attainment, and that a Mason will always be in search of more light.

An equally significant ceremony is that of Approaching the East. The East is the source of Light.

The Altar is the most important article of furniture in a Lodge-room- a place at the center around which all else revolves.

The Obligations have in them many literal meanings and as such are the foundations of our disciplinary law but, over and above this, they signify the nature and place of obligation in human life. A righteous man can be depended upon to fulfill his obligations to the best of his ability.

The Rite of Salutation, in which the candidate salutes each station, is a symbol of a Mason's respect for and obedience to all just and duly constituted authorities.

The same significance is had by the office of Worshipful Master who is a symbol as well as the executive officer of the Lodge. As the sun rules the day, he rules and governs his Lodge. His title "Worshipful" means that as the governor he is worthy of reverence, respect and obedience.

The Apron is at once the emblem of purity and badge of a Mason.

In the Rite of Destitution, the candidate discovers that he has nothing of a metallic character on his person. The candidate is not to bring into the Lodge-room his passions or prejudices lest the harmony, which is one of the chief concerns of Masonry to sustain, will be destroyed.

The Northeast Corner is traditionally the place where the cornerstone of a building is laid; when the Apprentice is made to stand there, it is because he is the cornerstone of the future Craft. What the Apprentices are today Masonry will become in the future.

The Working Tools represent those moral and spiritual virtues, habits and forces by means of which a man is enabled to reshape the crude and often stubborn materials of his nature in order to adjust himself to the need and requirements of human society. If a man has lived planlessly, carelessly, without aim or ideal he must, if he is to become a Mason, learn to systematize his life, must adopt a plan as signified by the Twenty-four Inch Gauge. If he has traits of temper, habits of speech or defects of character that disturb or injure others and interfere with his taking his proper place in the Brotherhood, he must rid himself of them. This is represented by the Common Gavel.

The Entered Apprentice is himself a symbol. He represents youth, trained youth, willing to submit itself to discipline and seek knowledge in order to learn the great Art of life, which is the real Royal Art, and which itself is represented and interpreted by all the Mysteries of Masonry.

Place of the Obligations in Masonic Law

Meeting No. 2

Subject No. 4

As an Entered Apprentice you have already taken the first of three obligations; the next will make you a Fellowcraft Mason; the third will make you a Master Mason.

If at this stage, you pause to reflect upon the meaning and place of obligations in Masonry, more particularly in the law of Masonry, you will be enabled to assume your next obligations with greater interest and a clearer understanding.

“Obligation” is one of those words which define themselves. The root of it is the same as the root of our word “ligament” and means a cord or tendon by which one thing is tied to another. An obligation, therefore, is a solemn pledge, made on a man’s honor, by which he ties himself to a society and at the same time himself to the duties and responsibilities imposed by it. Such an obligation a man cannot disregard except at the cost of traducing his own honor. The Masonic obligations are taken by the candidate as binding without limit of time; that is, he accepts them for the remainder of his natural life; he may possibly in the future withdraw from the Fraternity or by it be suspended or expelled, but that will not ease him of his pledge because he took that pledge, not as a Lodge member, but as a man. This is the meaning of the old saying: “Once a Mason, always a Mason.”

Upon taking the obligation you became an Entered Apprentice. Your obligation may be divided into “affirmative points” and “negative points”. The positive points consist of those clauses which require certain acts to be done; the negative points are those which forbid that other acts be done. Both the positive and the negative points are covered by one general point requiring that the whole obligation be kept in strictest secrecy; this is called the “Tie.”

No man can take a Masonic obligation that may be considered binding unless he is of lawful age and unless he is of sound mind, not insane nor in his dotage. This means that the candidate taking it accepts, and is competent to accept, full responsibility for it. If afterwards he is charged with having violated any of the points, he cannot seek to evade the consequences by pleading ignorance or inability at the time he gave his pledge. This is all of a piece with Freemasonry's attitude to the candidate throughout; no pressure is brought to bear upon him, no undue influence he comes unsolicited and of his own free will and accord, as a free man in every sense of the word; he is left free to withdraw before taking any obligation; in short, it is ascertained at every step that he is competent and, to that end, he is responsible for every promise he makes and every pledge he gives.

There is among the laws of Masonry a set of laws which regulate an individual's conduct as a Mason; these lay down what is demanded of him in conduct, define Masonic crimes and affix certain penalties. These may be described as the disciplinary laws of the Craft. In the majority of cases brought to trial for un-Masonic conduct it is this disciplinary law that is involved. The important point about our disciplinary law is that the obligations are its foundation. Pay close attention to this fact and for this reason: the obligations appear as a portion of the Ritual; much of that Ritual is symbolical and not to be taken literally, therefore, you may be tempted to feel that the obligations also are merely symbolical and are a kind of formality of ceremony; this is not true, for the obligations are in force in the same manner as all other definite law, are in fact themselves law in its most definite and specific sense. This is important for you to know and to remember in the outset of your Masonic career, because the obligation will always remain binding. Your conduct as a Mason is not left to the guidance of any vague mood or uncertain feeling but is to be governed according to strict and clearly stated rules.

You may wish to know why it is, if this be true, that the penalties attached to the obligations are of a type so different from the obligations proper. If the positive and negative points of the obligations

proper to be taken literally, why not also the penalties? The answer is that the penalties are to be taken as they stand when they are correctly understood. The form of these penalties comes to us from history. Speculative Freemasonry began in England with the organization of the first Grand Lodge in 1717. At that time all crimes were understood to belong to either of two classes, heresy or treason. By heresy was meant some violation of the religious principles, morals and ideals of the State; by treason was meant some crime against the political and legal authority of the State. Two sets of punishments, familiar to everybody for three or four centuries, became so identified with the two types of crime that they became synonymous with them. You can now understand our own penalties; they mean that any crime against Masonry is either heresy-that is, a violation of its teachings; or treason-that is, against the authority of Lodge or Grand Lodge or against our laws. The penalties are a symbolical presentation of that truth, and truth it is because a Mason may be punished for violating the official teachings of Masonry as surely as for violating its written laws.

As for punishments literally in force, they may be, as our Code states: reprimand, suspension from all the rights of Masonry for a definite time, and expulsion. The penalties attached to the obligations express the general nature of the offense; the penalties prescribed in the Trial Code describe the punishments literally in force.

At no point does our Fraternity transgress upon the province of the civil authorities-to do so would violate the Landmarks-but within its own province it is itself a system of law and order. A body of unwritten law is in force within it; the Lodge and Grand Lodge may make and interpret the law; certain Lodge and Grand Lodge officers enforce the law; and both the Lodge and Grand Lodge may sit as courts for the trial of cases, may hear testimony, decide innocence or guilt and affix penalties.

Such facts as these are of paramount importance to you as you form your conception of Freemasonry. Our Craft is not a formless social circle but a completely organized institution in which law, the

enforcement of law, and punishment for crime are as serious and real as they are anywhere outside it. The obligations, as the climax and summit of each of the Degrees, are an expression of this and are a visible embodiment of our system of law and order.

The Mason as a Citizen

Meeting No. 2

Subject No. 5

In the Old Charges it is laid down as a fundamental law of the Craft that "a Mason is a peaceable subject to the Civil Powers, wherever he resides or works, and is never to be concerned in Plots and Conspiracies against the peace and welfare of the Nation ... " The Charge to the Entered Apprentice states: "in the State, you are to be a quiet and peaceful citizen, true to your government and just to your country. You are not to countenance disloyalty or rebellion, but patiently to submit to legal authority, and conform with cheerfulness to the government of the country in which you live."

At the time the Old Charges were written the people had no voice in their government; they were ruled by kings, and often the dynasty to which a king belonged was challenged in its right to rule by some other dynasty; a rebellion or a revolution was the only method by which a government could be changed. Almost every organization, including even churches and colleges, took sides with one dynasty as against the other. Masonic law took the position that this system of warring parties was hurtful to mankind and a great danger to a people, and that it ought to be replaced by the principle of goodwill and peaceable co.-operation.

Here in America we have no king or dynasties, but we continue to have parties. Instead of quarreling with each other as to what the government shall be, our parties are in contention as to what the government shall do; and instead of deciding which one shall triumph by means of rebellions and revolutions, our parties make use of political campaigns, and while these campaigns do not result in the shedding of blood they often result in a great deal of bitterness. In the face of this modern situation our Craft continues to take the same position that it took in an earlier time; it believes that these bitter, partisan contentions are hurtful to the people, subversive of sound government and that the welfare of the State can be best secured by

good-will, toleration and a patient, friendly co-operation. It, therefore, refuses to participate in partisan politics and forbids its members ever to do so in the name of Masonry.

It is now possible for us to define the Masonic conception of citizenship. It means that in all his relations with the community and the State a man is motivated and controlled by the principle of fraternalism, which means that as one of the people, he works for and with the people in the spirit of goodwill and for the general good. He is to apply fraternalism in detail in such manner as meets with his best judgment.

A Mason may be an active worker in some political party: what party it is, is for him to decide; but as a Mason he will not hate those who differ from him, nor enter unjust intrigues against them; he will not set up his own party in opposition to the public good, nor will he proselyte for supporters among his Brethren.

He may be an active member of a church, and as a Mason he will have goodwill toward men of a different faith; he will not be actuated by prejudice or intolerance, nor will he be a party to making war upon any other religious communion however much in error he may deem it to be.

In his social life he may belong to any circle he wishes, wealthy or poor, and enjoy the companionship of such as please him, nobody else having any right to dictate; but as a Mason he will not consider his own circle above others, or despise those who may not be as fortunate as he in his social relations-for such snobbery is repugnant to the principle of fraternalism.

Again, it is possible that he may feel a pride of race, may cherish the traditions of his own people, may love its language and prefer its customs; if so, nobody has the right to forbid him, for it is right and honorable in every man to respect his own blood; but as a Mason he will not, therefore, despise others of a different race, nor seek at their expense to exalt his own; for there is nothing more un-Masonic than race prejudice.

Freemasonry leaves it wholly to us to decide what form our citizenship shall take in detail or where we shall find our own niche in the great structure of public life.

You will now understand why neither a Lodge, nor Grand Lodge nor any group of Masons as such, ever interfere with matters of church, state, or society, or joins one party as against another. It is not inconsistent for the Craft to perform such services to the community as stand by common consent on a level beyond all parties.

Lodges or groups of their members have assisted to raise funds for or to build public libraries. Also, the Craft appears publicly to lay the cornerstone of some public building.

For many generations it has been especially friendly to the public schools, not alone because its own motto is: "Let there be Light," but in order to assist the children of every family in a community to enjoy educational advantages regardless of race, or creed, or party.

To sum up:

If a Mason asks, "How am I to apply the teachings of Masonry to Citizenship?" - the answer is:

That is for you to decide and according as you have opportunity. All that is required of you is to be guided throughout by the principle of fraternalism.

Interpretation of the Ritual of the Second Degree

Meeting No. 3

Subject No. 1

You are now a Fellowcraft Mason. Because the Fellowcraft Degree chances to lie between the Entered Apprentice and Master Mason Degrees you must not permit yourself to fall into the error of considering it a half-way station, a mere transition from one to the other. It has in itself the same completeness, the same importance, as each of the other two, with a definite purpose of its own.

There are two great ideas embodied in the Fellowcraft Degree. They are not the only ideas in it, but if you understand them, they will lead you into an understanding of the others.

One of these is the idea of adulthood.

Whereas the Entered Apprentice represents youth standing at the portals of life, his eyes on the rising sun, the Fellowcraft is a man in the prime of life-experienced, strong, resourceful, able to bear the heat and burden of the day.

When he comes to experience adulthood, a man discovers that the mere fact that he is forty or fifty years of age has little to do with it. Adulthood is a condition, a state of life, a station charged with a set of duties.

What does the Second Degree have to say to the Fellowcraft, whether in Masonry or in the world at large? The answer to that brings us to our second idea. That idea is that the Fellowcraft may so equip himself that he will prove adequate to the tasks which will be laid upon him.

What is that equipment? The Degree gives us at least three answers. Let us ponder each of them a moment.

The first answer is that the Fellowcraft must gain direct experience from contact with the realities of existence. You will recall

what was said about the Five Senses. Needless to say, that portion of the Middle Chamber Lecture was not intended to be a disquisition on either physiology or psychology; it is symbolism and represents what a man learns through seeing, touching, tasting, hearing and smelling-in short, experience from year to year until, at last, through the very contacts of his senses with the objects which make up the world, he has come to understand that world, how to deal with it, how to master it at the point where he stands.

The second answer is education. After all, an individual's possible experience is extremely limited, circumscribed by the length of his Cable Tow. To our own store of hard-won experience, we must add the experience of others, supplementing our experience by the information of countless men brought to us by the knowledge taught us by the race and its teachers.

Consider the Apprentice in the days when Masons were builders of great and costly structures. He was a mere boy entirely ignorant of the secrets and arts of the builders; and yet, after seven years or so he was able to produce his master's piece and take his place at any task to which the Worshipful Master might appoint him. This was accomplished by teaching, by the Master Masons about him guiding his clumsy hands and passing on to him in many lessons what they had been years in acquiring.

Such is education. It is symbolized in the Second Degree by the Liberal Arts and Sciences. Perhaps you were somewhat non-plussed to hear what was said about grammar, rhetoric, logic, arithmetic, astronomy and music, and wondered what such school-room topics had to do with Masonry. You understand now. The explanation of these subjects was not meant to be an academic lecture out of a college course; like so much else in the Degree it was symbolism, and symbolism signifies all that is meant by education.

A Fellowcraft of life then must be equipped with experience and knowledge. Is there anything more? Yes, there is a third answer. That third answer is wisdom.

A man may see, hear, touch, and handle things so much that he wins a rich experience, and yet not have knowledge, he may have such knowledge, he may have mastered some task , or art, or trade, and yet be unhappy and a failure as a human being because he cannot adjust himself to the complex system of realities, experience and facts which make up life as a whole. He may lack wisdom- competency to deal with each situation that arises, it matters not what it may be.

The Middle Chamber, which is so conspicuous an element in the Second Degree doubtless has many meanings, but it most certainly has this-that it is a symbol of the wisdom of which I have just been speaking. Through the experience of the Five Senses, up through the knowledge gained of the Liberal Arts and Sciences, the candidate is called to advance, as on a Winding Stair, to that balanced wisdom of life in which the senses, emotions, intellect, character, work, deeds, habits and soul of a man are knit together in unity-balanced, poised, adequate.

This interpretation of the Fellowcraft Degree touches but the hem of its manifold meanings. It has been my purpose only to give you certain suggestions, and I hope that with them now in your possession you may be inspired to search out all the other meanings for yourself.

Symbols and Allegories of the Second Degree

Meeting No. 3

Subject No. 2

In my brief talk I shall confine myself to those symbols and allegories that belong particularly to the Second Degree. Among the allegories peculiar to it, the most striking and important one is that rite in which you, as a candidate, acted the part of a man approaching King Solomon's Temple. You came into its outer precincts, passed between the two pillars, climbed a winding stair and at last, after passing through an outer and an inner door, entered its Middle Chamber. Standing in it you acted the part of a Fellowcraft workman who received his wages of Corn, Wine and Oil; and during certain stages of this allegorical journey you listened to various parts of a discourse which Masonry calls the Middle Chamber Lecture.

This entire acted allegory is a symbolic picture of the true and inner meaning of initiation. The Temple is the life into which a man is initiated. The stairs you climbed represented the steps by which the life of initiation is approached- qualification, petition, election and the Degrees. The Pillars represent birth; when you passed between them it signified that you were no longer a profane but had now entered the circle of initiates. The Middle Chamber represents initiation completed; once arrived there the candidate receives the rewards for the ordeals and arduous labors he has endured on the way; he has arrived at his goal.

The whole process of Masonic initiation is itself a symbolic allegory, so that in this central portion of the Degree we have an allegory within an allegory. We must ask then what is symbolized by Masonic initiation itself.

The answer is that it symbolizes, and in so doing interprets the experience of every man who seeks the good life; and by interpreting it teaches us how the good life is found.

Consider that form of the good life which we are seeking when we seek education or enlightenment. In the beginning man is a profane, stands in the outside darkness, is in that ignorance from which he would escape into the Inner Chamber of knowledge. How is he qualified? By having the necessary desire to learn and by possessing the required faculties and abilities. How does he find his way? By trusting to his guides, that is his teachers and books. He must feel his way along from stage to stage for he has never walked it before; it is an ascending path that is laborious, arduous, difficult, for there is no royal road to learning. What is the door through which he can enter? It is a door composed of the Two Pillars, which means birth; this signifies that knowledge must be won inside our natures; others may assist but their assistance is limited; each man must learn by his own efforts; knowledge is never permanently won until it is made a part of ourselves.

The value of enlightenment is represented by the Temple, set apart from the world of ignorance, won at the cost of great sacrifice.

The belief that the goods of life come by luck is a most fatal blunder. The satisfying goods of life, whether they be spiritual, moral, intellectual or physical, have a nature which renders it impossible for them ever to be won by luck. They cannot come at all except by our toiling to make them come and even then, they cannot come except at the cost of change and transformations in our own natures which are often painful and costly to make.

Such is the meaning of our allegorical entrance into King Solomon's Temple as a candidate in the Second Degree. You can see at once that all other symbols and allegories in the Degree are to be interpreted in the light of that meaning; that in the light of that meaning the Degree itself becomes a living power by which to shape and build our lives, not only in the Lodge-room itself but in the world of human experience of which the Lodge-room is a symbol.

Duties and Privileges of a Fellowcraft

Meeting No. 3

Subject No. 3

The duties of a Fellowcraft are quickly described. His first and foremost duty is to live according to the obligations of the Degree; to be obedient to the officers of the Lodge and to the rules, regulations and laws of the Fraternity. Also, he must learn well the catechism in order to pass his test for proficiency, and it is expected that he will attend the Lodge when opened on his Degree as often as possible. If he be earnest and sincere, he will study to understand the meaning of the Degree as a preparation for his Masonic life.

His limitations are equally plain. He cannot sit in Lodge when opened on the Third Degree; he is not entitled to vote, to hold office, to have a voice in the business of the Lodge, or to enjoy such privileges of relief, burial, etc., as are reserved to Master Masons only.

As privileges or rights, he can visit or sit in any regular Lodge opened in the First or Second Degrees; he can ask to be coached and instructed and may counsel with well-informed Brethren; he can make himself known to other Fellowcrafts by means of his modes of recognition; and within the necessary limits he may enjoy the social fellowship of the Lodge.

But all this falls far short of what it means to be a Fellowcraft Mason.

First, a Mason remains a Fellowcraft in every respect, save in the legal sense, as long as he lives. To make this plain let me ask you to imagine the taking of the First Degree as being like the drawing of a circle; the Second Degree is a circle drawn around the outside of the first; the Third Degree is a still larger circle drawn around the other two, and containing them both. A portion of the whole of Freemasonry is contained within the first circle, another portion is in the second, a third portion is in the last. Or if you wish to describe it in another

manner, being a Master Mason includes within itself, and all at one stroke, being also an Apprentice Mason and a Fellowcraft Mason. The Apprentice and Fellowcraft Degrees are not like the stages left behind in a journey and, therefore, to be abandoned or forgotten, but rather they are taken up, preserved and incorporated in the Master Mason Degree.

To understand Freemasonry in its entirety, it is, therefore, as necessary for you to grasp it as it presents itself in the Second Degree as elsewhere.

In the Fellowcraft Degree we are put into possession of the Masonry of the mind.

In the Entered Apprentice Degree, we have the Masonry of conscience, where we are taught how necessary is obedience, apprenticeship and industriousness if we would become good men and true. In the Third Degree we have, as you will learn in due time the Masonry of the soul, in which the candidate learns the secret of the spiritual life. Running through all three Degrees we have the Masonry of the sentiments: fellowship, goodwill, kindness, affection, brotherly love, etc.

What is this Masonry of the Mind? It is the Masonry which has as its motto: "Let there be Light;" which declares ignorance to be one of the worst of misfortunes and one of the deadliest of enemies; which proclaims that enlightenment is one of the great goods of life; and which holds that a man must be a Mason in his head as well as in his heart.

That this is not an idle or fanciful picture is proved by the history of Freemasonry itself. It was established some six centuries ago by the Operative builders, who gave the world, among their other masterpieces, the great Gothic cathedrals of Europe. Their art was at once the highest and most difficult practiced in their period, and that art was built on what we now call science. Through all the changes of the Craft in after years, through its transformation two hundred years ago into a Speculative Fraternity, that great intellectual tradition of theirs has remained at the forefront, and stands today embodied in

the Second Degree, which exists to teach Masons to be lovers of the Liberal Arts and Sciences.

This Masonry of the mind is the inner essence and real meaning of the Second Degree; so that hereafter whenever as a Mason you prove yourself a friend of enlightenment, whenever you become a champion of the mind's right to be free, to do its work without check or hindrance, or become the enemy of bigotry or intolerance, support schools and colleges, and labor to translate into fact and action the motto: "Let there be Light," you will be living out in your life the teachings of the Fellowcraft Degree.

The Teachings of Masonry

Meeting No. 3

Subject No. 4

Already you have discovered that Masonry's teaching is unlike that of the schools. This is not as easy to follow as the school-room method, but over that method it has this one great advantage: it makes a Mason study and learn for himself, forces him to search out the truth, compels him to take the initiative, as a grown man should, so that the very act of learning is in itself of great educational value. The purpose of secrecy is not to keep a candidate in the dark, but to stimulate him to seek the light; the symbols and emblems do not conceal the teaching, they reveal it; but they reveal it in such a manner than a man must find it for himself.

Freemasonry has three tenets, or great teachings; these are Brotherly Love, Relief and Truth.

Freemasonry is a Fraternity devoted to Brotherhood-but this Brotherhood must be understood in a special sense. Freemasonry's position is that Brotherhood rests on a religious basis; we are all Brothers, or should be, because God is the Father of us all; therefore, religion is one of the foundations of Masonry.

Masonry is dedicated to God, the Sovereign Grand Architect of the Universe. It keeps an Altar at the center of every Lodge-room and the Holy Bible lies open upon that Altar. It begins and ends its undertakings with prayer. _It~ petitioners must believe in God. All this is genuine religion, not a formal religiousness. But this religion of Masonry, like all else in its teaching, is not set forth in written creeds or in any other form of words; the Mason must come upon it for himself, and put it in such form as will satisfy his own mind.

Along with religion, Masonry teaches the necessity of morality, requiring of its members that they be good men and true, righteous when tried by the Square, upright when tried by the Plumb, their passions kept in due bounds by the Compasses, just in their dealings

with their fellows, patient with the erring, charitable, truthful, honorable.

Of the theological virtues of Faith, Hope and Charity our Craft says, as did the Apostle, that “the greatest of these is Charity,” and each of us must stand ready at any and all times privately to extend a helping hand in relief of an unfortunate Brother, or his dependents. Masonry, however, unlike some of the sects and cults, does not advocate a charity carried to the limits of fanaticism; there is such a thing as a Cable Tow, the extent of ability and opportunity, and we are not expected to give relief beyond the point where it would work damage to ourselves or hardship to our families.

Another of Masonry’s great teachings is Equality, symbolized by the Level. This does not represent that impossible doctrine which would erase all distinctions and holds that in all respects all men are the same, for it is evident that in many respects men are very unequal, as in physique, in talent, in gifts, in abilities, and in character; it is, rather, the principle that we owe good will, charity, tolerance and truthfulness equally to each and all, and that within our Fraternity all men travel the same road of initiation, take the same obligations, pay the same dues and have the same duties, rights and privileges.

A like importance is attached to the need for enlightenment. The motto of Masonry is: “Let there be Light.” and almost the whole of the Second Degree is a drama of education. There is a Masonry of the mind as well as of the heart and of the hand. To reverence the wise, to respect teachers, to value and uphold schools and to encourage the Liberal Arts and Sciences is one of our most ancient traditions.

Outside the Lodge-room the Mason is to be good citizen, loyal to his government, taking no part in broils and rebellions, conducting himself as a moral and wise man, remembering in all things that he has in his keeping the good name of the Fraternity.

These teachings arise out of the nature and needs of that Brotherhood for the sake of which the whole system of the Craft exists. To endure through all vicissitudes and to satisfy our natures, Brotherhood must have a spiritual basis, hence the all-importance of

our foundation of religion. Brotherhood requires that men must be held together by unbreakable ties, hence the necessity for morality which is a name for the forces that bind us in the relations of amity and accord. Difference of beliefs and opinions must not be permitted to rupture those bonds, hence the need for tolerance. Men cannot come together or remain together except they have the same rights and privileges, hence the necessity of equality. They cannot work together except they all understand the work to be done, hence the need for enlightenment. They will not be drawn together except they are filled with that spirit of good-will which necessarily expresses itself in charity and relief. And a Brotherhood itself cannot exist except in a society which admits it, hence the need for Masons to be good citizens. Through all the teachings of Masonry run these principles which lead back to its conception and practice of brotherhood. Gain a clear understanding of that and you will have that Royal Secret by which all else is made plain.

I have two suggestions to make to you, each of which, if you will adopt it, will be of inestimable value to you as you ponder the teachings of Masonry.

One of these is that you study carefully the Old Charges of a Freemason. These were the Charges given to the candidates by the old Operative Masons to define and explain the Masonic life; they were used for centuries and they continue to be a body of unwritten law in which every aspect of Masonry finds expression.

The other is that you study with equal care the following statement: "Masonry teaches man to practice charity and benevolence, to protect chastity, to respect the ties of blood and friendship, to adopt the principles and revere the ordinances of religion, to assist the feeble, guide the blind, raise up downtrodden, shelter the orphan, guard the altar, support the government, inculcate morality, promote learning, love man, fear God, implore His mercy and hope for happiness."

Masonic Education

Meeting No. 3

Subject No. 5

I hope you may not permit the word education to prejudice you against my subject. As we employ the word it refers to those means by which a Mason may learn what he needs and desires to learn about our Fraternity in order to understand and appreciate it and take a worthy part in it- a subject which stands at the center of the Second Degree and one for which we are sure you already have discovered the necessity.

The member of a golf club or a card club or a fishing or hunting club is not obliged to pass through a course of instruction to understand it.

Freemasonry is a different kind of organization. It is so different that it is not easy to think of any other society with which to compare it. Masonry is not an obvious and familiar thing a man already understands when he joins it, but it is rather something that must be learned. In order that this may be made more plain let us consider a few facts.

Masonry is so organized that a man cannot be admitted to it merely by paying a fee and signing a book. He must pass through a series of initiations which require of him that he study and learn much. It does not entice men in its membership by offering them pleasures and indulgences, but calls them, if they are properly qualified and have the motive, to the living of a certain kind of life.

What this life is it does not set forth in a few simple rules but bodies forth in a system of ritual and symbolism. This system cannot be understood in a few minutes. It calls for study, reflection, a vigorous application of the mind.

One of the peculiarities of Masonry is the place occupied by it in history. Our history which is very ancient, is interesting as such; but infinitely more than this it is a living and active part of our work, not

something dead and done with but vital and close to us. There is no dead hand of the past in Masonry; the hand of the past is alive, holds us in a strong grip, and shapes and determines much that we do. One cannot understand Masonry apart from its history.

Of like bearing is the fact that Masonry in one of its aspects exists as a system of laws. These laws are in the form of Ancient Landmarks, Old Charges, Constitutions, traditions, usages, edicts, laws, regulations, customs, By-laws, and authority vested in officers. Whatever is done in Masonry is done lawfully. The Craft is not like an open enclosure in which, after he has passed the barrier, every man is left free to do as he pleases; but rather it is like an organism in which each part and organ acts according to the law of the whole.

Consider also the offices in the Masonic system. They carry with them heavy responsibilities. The Worshipful Master, for example, is not simply a presiding officer, but is indeed and in truth a Master, the executive head of the Lodge, responsible for its welfare to the Grand Lodge. To qualify for such an office he must pass through a long apprenticeship in active work, serve as a Warden and he must learn thoroughly the ritual of all three Degrees as well as the opening and closing ceremonies and rules of order, to say nothing of the laws and practices.

If our form of organization is complex it is because our activities are many. Freemasonry is a world-wide Fraternity. Here in our country it has Lodges in almost every community. All these Lodges are busy constantly; together with their two and one-half million members, they make up a great world within the world. When a man becomes a Mason, it is this world he enters; consequently, if he is to take interest in his Masonry, he will wish to know something about all these activities.

As you enter this great world of Masonry you will not be content to look on from a distance, but he will be eager to enter into it, to take a part in its affairs, and to enjoy to the full the rich life that pulsates through it. What we describe as education is just the ways and means of doing so.

We recommend that, while learning the catechism of the three Degrees you learn thoroughly. As time passes you will find this to be a foundation upon which you can build a satisfying Masonic career; it will make it easier for you to take part in Lodge life, to visit other Lodges, perhaps to hold office, and at the same time it will be a possession for you within your own mind, from which you will constantly draw inspiration and light in your daily life.

We recommend that you attend Lodge as frequently and regularly as possible. One can best learn Masonry by practice, by actually engaging in it and of all the schools of the Craft the Lodge itself is the best. Moreover, in attending Lodge you will form those close associations with other Brethren that will in time ripen into enduring friendships- one of the great rewards of loyal service.

We recommend that as soon as you have become qualified or equipped, and as opportunities arise, you will stand willing to take an active part, not content with remaining on one side. This does not mean necessarily to hold office or to participate in the Degree work; the work of Masonry is far wider than that.

We recommend that you read a few books about the Craft, especially some brief but reliable history and a volume or two on our ritual and teachings. A few hours spent with such books will prove an investment of great value in the future.

We are confident that this description of the task of being a Mason will neither depress nor discourage you, but rather will be an inspiration to you, a challenge to your best endeavors, a proof to you of the richness and value of that life with us into which you are now entering.

The Interpretation of the Ritual of the Third Degree

Meeting No. 4

Subject No. 1

You have been raised to the Sublime Degree of Master Mason. It is indeed a “sublime” Degree which a man may study for years to come without exhausting it.

A hint may stimulate a man to reflect upon it for himself and to study it more

thoroughly in the future.

In the First and Second Degrees you were surrounded by the symbols and emblems of architecture; in the Third Degree you found a different order of symbolism, cast in the language of the soul-its life, its tragedy and its triumph. To recognize this is the first step in interpretation.

The second step is to recognize that the Third Degree has many meanings; it is not intended to be a lesson complete, finished, closed.

There are many interpretations of the Degree, all true. But most essentially it is a drama of the immortality of the soul, setting forth the truth that while a man withers away and perishes, there is that in him which perishes not.

That this is the meaning most generally accepted by the Craft is shown by our habits of language; we say that a man is initiated an Entered Apprentice, passed a Fellowcraft and raised a Master Mason; by this it appears that it is the raising that most Masons have found at the center of the Master Mason Degree.

What does this raising signify? If you have the answer to this question you can afterwards find your own way into all the meanings of the Degree.

The life of man is organized in a number of groups of experiences, each different from the others. Some experiences are incidental to our passage through time from childhood, through manhood, to old age. Some are incidental to the life of the body, hunger, sleep, weariness. Others cluster about the home and family; about religion, the meaning and purpose of life. Yet others have to do with a man's work, his trade or occupation. Some center about his life in the community as a neighbor or a citizen. Unless one be adequate to deal with all these groups of experiences, he cannot be happy.

The most difficult of all to deal with is that made up of the evils of life; hard experiences; sin, defeat, disease, loss of friends or fortune, enmity, treachery, sorrow, death. Herein lie our greatest problems, our severest testing. If we can find the wisdom to deal with these, if we can triumph over and solve their problems, our characters will be secure, our happiness assured. What you doing about evil in yourself and in the world about you? This is a question life asks each of us. If we fail of the right answer it enforces the worst of all penalties.

If evil come upon a man by his own acts, we feel that it is a just compensation; but what of the evil that comes upon a good man? Such we call tragedy, the supreme evil.

Evil in the form of tragedy is set forth in the Drama of the Third Degree. Here is a good and wise man, a builder, working for others and giving others work, the highest we know, as it is dedicated wholly to God. Through no fault of his own he experiences tragedy from friends and fellow Masons. Here is evil pure and unalloyed, a complete picture of human tragedy.

How did the Craft meet this tragedy? The first step was to impose the supreme penalty on those who had possessed the will to destruction and therefore had to be destroyed lest another tragedy fallow. The greatest enemy man has makes war upon the good; to it no quarter can be given.

The next step was to discipline and to pardon those who acted not out of an evil will, but out of weakness. Forgiveness is possible if a

man himself condemns the evil he has done, since in spite of his weakness he retains his faith in the good.

The next step was to recover from the wreckage caused by the tragedy whatever of value it had left undestroyed. Confusion had come upon the Craft; order was restored. Loyal Craftsmen took up the burdens dropped by traitors. It is in the nature of such tragedy that the good suffer for the evil, and it is one of the prime duties of life that a man shall toil to undo the harm wrought by sin and crime, else in time the world would be destroyed by the evils that are done in it.

But what of the victim of the tragedy? Here is the most profound and most difficult lesson of the Drama, difficult to understand, difficult to believe if one has not been truly initiated into the realities of the spiritual life. Because the victim was a good man, his goodness rooted in an unvarying faith in God, that which destroyed him in one sense could not destroy him in another. The spirit in him rose above the reach of evil; by virtue of it he was raised from a dead level to a living perpendicular.

Let us imagine a genuinely good man who has been the victim of the most terrible of tragedies, one caused by the treachery of friends. This treachery has brought destruction upon the foundations of his life, his home, his reputation, his ability to earn a livelihood. How can he be raised above the clutch of such circumstances? How can he emerge a happier man than before? By his spirit rising to the plane of forgiveness, refusing to stoop to retaliation or to harbor bitterness. In such a spirit the truest happiness is found.

The secret of such a power is in the Third Degree, symbolized by the Word. If that Word is lost, a man must search for it; if a man possesses that Word, he has the secret of the Masonic Art. To rise to the height of spiritual life is to stand on a level above the reach of tragedy or the powers of evil. To have the spirit rest in God, to have a sincere and unvarying faith in truth and goodness, is the inner secret of a Master Mason, to teach which is the purpose of the Third Degree.

Symbols, Emblems, and Allegories of the Third Degree

Meeting No. 4.

Subject No. 2.

In your experience with the Ritual you have learned that every detail in the ceremonies of initiation is full of meaning. In the Third Degree are the deepest secrets and the most profound teachings of our Fraternity. You passed through the Degree in one night: to understand it will require many nights. In these few minutes we can give you a few hints, in the hope that they may inspire you to study the Degree for yourself.

The symbolism of the First and Second Degrees centers around the art of architecture; their purpose is to teach you, in the First, to be a builder of yourself, in the Second, a builder of society. In the Third Degree the symbolism takes another form. Although its background continues to be architecture, and its action takes place in and about a Temple, it is a spiritual symbolism of life and death. Its principal teaching is of immortality.

If a man permit himself to be buried under the rubbish of sins and passions, it is possible, if he has learned the secret of the spiritual life and with the help of God and of the Brotherhood, to rise again into a new life. This gives us the key to the Degree, and in its light, all its symbols, emblems, allegories must be understood.

This note is struck in the Scripture Reading from the Book of Ecclesiastes, which pictures a man once flushed with health and strength, brought tottering by old age to the brink of the grave. This Chapter tells us, will become a light burden to him who has learned to trust God. God is the God of old age and of the soul after death as much as of youth and strength.

The Working Tools of the Degree are all the implements of Masonry, but more especially the Trowel by which we spread the cement of Brotherly Love. But Brotherly Love itself has its source and

seat in the soul. To love a man above his sins, to cherish him in spite of his faults, to forgive him in all sincerity, is possible only as we live in the spiritual life, our souls purged of selfishness.

The Tragedy of Hiram Abif is the climax of the Degree; is indeed the climax of all the ceremonies of Freemasonry. Next in importance is the allegorical Search for That Which Was Lost. This has a historical background. To the early Jewish people, the name of God was held in extreme reverence. This Holy name was never pronounced above a whisper; after a while only the priests were permitted to use it; finally only the High Priest, and then only when alone in the Holy of Holies on the Day of Atonement. During some national calamity, perhaps at the time of the Babylonian Captivity, the High Priest was destroyed before he had opportunity to pass it on to his successor. In that way the Name was lost.

The Name might have been preserved in the sacred writings of the Jews except that in their written language the vowels were understood, not written. The consonants of the Divine Name are known, J H V H, but not the vowels and therefore not the name.

All this appears in our Ritual in the form of an allegory. A Word was possessed; the Word was lost.

Like all symbols this means many things. One of its profounder meanings is that if a man has lost the ideals of his youth, his character, his faith in truth and goodness, the secret of what it is to be a man, he must, if he is to live the Masonic Life, go in search of that which was lost and continue searching until he finds it. Without manhood it is useless to be a man.

You may wonder why the Ritual does not explain fully the meaning of this symbolism, why it leaves the candidate to find the meanings for himself. There are three reasons for this silence. First, lack of time. To explain them all fully would require not three nights but perhaps three hundred.

Second, the Masonic life grows by what we do for ourselves, infinitely more than what others do for us. The Ritual presupposes

that we are grown men, not boys in school, and that each of us does his own thinking. Third, the method of the Ritual is to bring us into the presence of the greater truths of life knowing that their mere presence will have a deep influence over us; each man is left to work them out in detail according to his own needs.

Of the Emblems of the Third Degree one after another is set before us, apparently in no given order, and each with only a hint of what it signifies. Yet each of them stands for some great idea or ideal, necessary throughout our lives; and the purpose is to plant them in our consciousness, to keep them always in our presence.

Each of them is a master of truth. In the Three pillars we have the three great ideas of wisdom, of strength or power, of beauty.

The three steps remind us that Youth, Manhood and Old Age is each a unity in itself each possessing its own duties and problems, each calling for its own philosophy. The Pot of Incense teaches that, to be pure and blameless in our inner lives is more acceptable to God than anything else.

What a man really is, is of vastly more importance than that which he appears to be. The Book of Constitutions is the emblem of Law and that our moral and spiritual character is grounded in law and order as much as in government or nature. It teaches that no man can live a satisfactory life who lives lawlessly. The Sword Pointed to the Naked Heart discovers that one of the most rigorous of these laws is justice, and that if a man be unjust in his heart, the inevitable results of injustice will find him out. The All-Seeing Eye shows that we live and move and have our being in God; that we are constantly in His Presence, wherever or whatever doing.

The Anchor and the Ark stand for that sense of security and stability of life grounded in truth and faith. The Forty-Seventh Problem is an emblem of the Arts and Sciences; by them we are reminded that next to sinfulness the most dangerous enemy of life is ignorance. In the Hourglass we have the emblem of the transitoriness of life; no man lives forever in this world. The Scythe reminds us that

passing time will bring an end to our lives as well as to our work, and if ever we are to become what we ought to be, we must not delay.

Unhappy the man who reaches middle years having missed these undeniable and all-important truths. He has gone backward, not forward and is not blameless in his heart. Yet there is hope for him. The central teaching of the Master Mason Degree, expressed in the Tragedy of Hiram Abif, is a way for him to recover possession of his life. He can be raised to a new manhood lifted from the dead level of death to a living perpendicular. He may be called back from a grave that is more terrible than the dissolution of the body. By repudiation and death of his old life, by gaining again his faith in God by the Power of Brotherhood, he finds the path to recovery.

The Legend of Hiram Abif

Meeting No. 4.

Subject No. 3.

In the Sublime Degree you were impressed by the Tragedy of Hiram Abif above all other features of its impressive ceremonies. As the Degree is the climax of initiation so is the Tragedy the climax of the Degree. To understand its meaning will be a prized possession as long as you live.

Drama is a conflict between a man and other men, or other forces, resulting in a crisis in which his life or fortune is at stake. The crisis, or problem, is followed by a resolution or solution; if it favors the man the drama is a comedy, in the original meaning of that word. If it turns against him, and he becomes a victim or a sufferer, the drama is tragedy. Plays acted on the stage are not dramas but representations of dramas. The Masonic Drama is of that which occurs in our own lives, to each of us in our daily experience.

The Tragedy of Hiram Abif is a ritualistic drama. Ritual is the set words and fixed ceremonies addressed to the human spirit through imagination. A play in the theatre may be built around some historical figure or event! as in Shakespeare's plays about the English Kings. If the figures and events are not actually historical, they are supposed to be, so that time, place and identity are of importance. A ritualistic drama moves wholly in the realm of the spirit, where time, space and particular individuals are ignored. The clash of forces, the crises and fates of the human spirit alone enter into it, and they hold true of all men everywhere.

Since the Drama of Hiram Abif is ritualistic, it is a mistake to accept it as history. There was a Hiram Abif in history, but our Third Degree goes far beyond what history tells of him. Our Hiram Abif is a symbol of the human soul. If, therefore, you have been troubled with the thought that some of the events of this drama could not have happened, you can ease your mind. If they never happened in history, they are symbols of what happens in the life of every man.

It is an inexcusable blunder to treat the drama as a mock tragedy, a serio-comedy. Savage peoples employ initiation ceremonies as an ordeal, but Freemasonry is not savage. Boys in school enjoy hazing but Freemasonry is not juvenile. The exemplification of our ritualistic drama should be as sincere, as solemn, as earnest as a prayer before the Altar; he who takes it trivially or with perverted humor, betrays a shallowness of soul which shows him unfit to be a Mason.

Hiram Abif is a symbol of the human soul. The work he was engaged to supervise is the symbol of the work we do, when we supervise, organize and direct our lives from birth to death. The enemies he met are symbols of those lusts and passions which in our breasts make war on our characters. His doom befalls every man who becomes a victim to those enemies; to be interrupted in his work, to be made outcast from the mastership over himself and, at the end, to be buried under all manner of rubbish, ill fame, defeat, demoralization, disgrace, weakness, misery, evil habits and scorn.

The manner in which he was raised from a dead level to a living perpendicular is the way by which any man rises from self-defeat to self-mastery. And the Great Architect, by the power of whose word Hiram Abif was raised, is the God in whose arms we ourselves forever lie, and whose mighty help we also need to raise us out of the grave of defeat.

Did you ask, while participating in that drama, why you were made to participate; why you were not permitted to sit as a spectator? It was YOUR drama not another's. No man can ever be a mere spectator of drama in his own soul. It was intended that your participation would prepare you for becoming a Master Mason by teaching you the secret of a Master Mason, by which the soul may rise above its internal enemies if a man is a Mason in reality as well as in name. The real Master Mason is master of himself.

Did you ask why the three enemies came from his own circle, not from the outside? The enemies most feared by the soul are always from within: its own ignorance, lust, passions, and sins. As the Great

Light reminds us, it is not that which kills the body that we need most to shun, but that which has power to destroy the spirit. Did you ask why it was that there was so much confusion among the Craftsmen? The temple is the symbol of a man's character, and therefore breaks and falls when the soul, its architect, is helpless.

The most we can obtain from others is such hints and suggestions as these. Print the story of Hiram Abif indelibly upon your mind: ponder it. When you are at grip with your enemies, recall it and act according to the light you find in it. Your inner self will give, in the form of first-hand experience, that which the drama gave in the form of Ritual, and you will be wiser and stronger for having the guidance and the light the Tragedy provides.

The Duties, Privileges, and Rights of a Master Mason

Meeting No. 4

Subject No. 4.

You will not find the duties, rights and privileges of a Master Mason anywhere clearly stated and numbered. They are scattered here and there; some are explicit, others are implied.

A Master Mason's first duty is obviously to live by and act consistently with his obligation. With this as a foundation, a number of those duties and rights can be discussed.

It is a Master Mason's duty to pay his share of the financial costs of the Fraternity, promptly and ungrudgingly. If he be unaffiliated, he has the right to petition for membership in some Lodge. He may choose the Lodge to which he makes his petition, but he should seek membership in some Lodge.

A Master Mason has the right to ask for a demit or a certificate of good standing and if he be clear of the books and no charges have been- or are about to be preferred against him the Lodge must grant it. One may hold his membership where he is happiest or it is most convenient, provided he is elected to membership in that Lodge.

Visiting in Lodges in which he does not hold membership is both a right and a privilege, though not a duty. It is a right in the sense that he may seek admittance into any regular Lodge; it is a privilege in the sense that his admission into that Lodge is contingent upon his being vouched for and being examined and being permitted to enter by the Worshipful Master.

If he seeks to visit a Lodge, he has the privilege of being vouched for if some member of it has sat in Lodge with him so that he is not compelled to undergo examination every time he seeks to visit. Masonic relief, like visiting, is both a right and a privilege. Every Mason has the lawful right to ask for it upon need, without derogation

to his dignity or endangering his standing. It is a privilege in that neither a Lodge nor a Master Mason is compelled to give relief. The Lodge is not an insurance society, an organized charity, or a death benefit association, nor is any guaranty given any member that he will receive what he asks. Each Lodge and each Mason is under obligation to heed the call for relief, but each is free to use judgment whether or not to extend relief.

If he be brought to trial in his own Lodge on charges of un-Masonic conduct and found guilty, he has the right of appeal to the Grand Lodge. This right is his guaranty against possible injustice or spiteful prosecution by some private enemy.

Every Master Mason has the right of Masonic burial (unless of course, the conduct of the deceased in his later years has reflected discredit upon the Fraternity).

Among the most important of his rights, though exercised under unhappy conditions, is his right of trial by his peers, under regulated conditions, with freedom to present evidence. This assures him that no Lodge can degrade him without a fair trial. Neither his Lodge nor any officer or member can remove him through malice or spite; nor can he be made to suffer the penalties of Masonry out of idle gossip or hearsay. Right of trial guarantees him all the securities of justice.

A Mason's privileges are to be described in principle and in spirit rather than in detail because they vary much and depend on local conditions. He has the right of a voice in his Lodge, a vote, and to hold office. He has also the privilege of giving Masonic service, one of the principal sources of the joy in Masonic life. A Lodge may do many things which are neither required nor prohibited by law; it may hold social affairs, give special entertainments, foster some Masonic educational enterprise, may have a library- all according to the wishes of its members. The Grand Lodge offers many privileges which are as open to the individual Mason as to the Lodge. Membership gives no man the right to demand things of either the Lodge or the Grand Lodge, but if they are offered, every member has the right to enjoy them.

Beyond all these specific duties, rights and privileges stands a more general region in which all are mingled together; the whole domain of Masonry's teachings, her Ritual and symbols, her history, her ideals of juris prudence, her philosophy, her literature, the whole Royal Art. It is the right of a Master Mason to be taught that Art and to have it in its fullness. Freemasonry in all her height, and breadth and length and richness belongs to you to use and enjoy.

The Grand Lodge Library and the Literature of Masonry

Meeting No. 4

Subject No. 5.

It has been said upon good authority that more books have been written about Freemasonry than upon any other single subject. The fact to be remembered is that we possess an extraordinarily rich literature about the Fraternity in all its branches and aspects, and any Brother who wishes to enjoy his Masonry to the full will necessarily make use of it.

Our literature divides itself naturally into a series of divisions:

HISTORY. Our written records cover some six centuries of time, but at the time

the first of these documents was written, which was about 1390 A. D., the Craft already was old; it had in its beginning inherited much from secret fraternities that had gone before; therefore our historians must go much farther back than 1390. At the same time, they must range far afield, and they must often deal with fraternities with which Freemasonry is, or has been historically connected. Speaking in the large, Masonic History breaks into the following subdivisions: general history, history country by country, history Grand Lodge by Grand Lodge, and Lodge history. In the same general field would fall biographies, histories of buildings, and histories of single objects Auch as Ancient Manuscripts, etc.

RITUAL AND SYMBOLISM. A writer on this subject might try to trace the origin of some element in the Ritual; or he might try to explain a symbol or ceremony; or interpret its meaning. A great mass of material exists on the Ritual in many languages and from every conceivable point of view of Masonic thought.

PHILOSOPHY. This deals with the teachings of Masonry, what Masonry stands for, what its ideals are, what it is trying to do. The

term “Masonic Philosophy” may be justly defined in either of two ways; it may mean an effort to study Masonry itself by philosophical methods as philosophers study other subjects; or it may mean Masonry's own philosophy of life.

JURISPRUDENCE. Masonic law exists in two main branches, Unwritten Law and Written Law. By Unwritten Law is not meant that it is never written down. Under this head fall the Ancient Landmarks, Old Charges, Ancient Constitutions, traditions, customs and usages. By the Written Law are meant Grand Lodge Constitutions, Codes, Statutes, Rules, Definitions, Regulations and Edicts, and Lodge By-Laws.

REFERENCE. By this is meant such books as dictionaries etc. Grand Lodge Proceedings, handbooks.

GENERAL LITERATURE. Under this is included fiction, poetry, drama, humor, music and all other such books as do not fall easily under the heads already given.

Doubtless you are asking in your mind how you may secure the use of this literature. Fortunately for us in this Jurisdiction a remarkably convenient and efficient means has been provided for us. In addition to the libraries of our respective Lodges, Grand Lodge maintains a Masonic Library at the Masonic Temple in Salt Lake City, which it places at the disposal of every Master Mason on our rolls. This includes you.

You may borrow books from the Grand Lodge Library in the same manner as from a public library or from your Lodge library. All you have to do is to register as a borrower giving the name and number of your Lodge. If a Mason lives near enough to visit it in person he may borrow books for a period of two weeks subject to renewal for two weeks; if not, he may borrow by mail, keeping them for two weeks subject to renewal for two weeks, the Library paying postage one way.

The Grand Secretary is ex-officio Grand Librarian. His office is in the Masonic Temple, Salt Lake City, adjoining the library. He, or any

member of the Grand Lodge Committee on Masonic Education, will assist any Brother in obtaining information about the library, its books and records.

You are urged to make use of this opportunity to find more light in Masonry and, while it is not in the province of this committee to lay out a recommended course of reading, least of all to suggest a list of titles, you are most earnestly counseled to read at least one modern, well-written book on each of the principal subjects; history, symbolism, ritual, philosophy, and juris prudence.

You have now entered that country called Freemasonry. It spreads out from your feet farther than your eyes can reach, through time and space. It belongs to you. Literature exists to help you put yourself in possession of it.

